50 per cent while that among children born with a weight above 2.5 kg is 34 per cent.

Household socio-economic status has a significant effect on children's nutrition status: Prevalence of malnutrition is significantly higher among children from low-income families. Children from Muslim or SC/ST households generally have worse nutrition indicators.

Girls' nutrition advantage over boys fades away with time: Nutrition advantage girls have over boys in the first months of life seems to be reversed over time as they grow older, potentially indicating neglect vis-à-vis girls in early childhood.

Mothers' education level determines children's nutrition: Prevalence of child underweight among mothers who cannot read is 45 per cent while that among mothers with 10 or more years of education is 27 per cent; 92 per cent mothers had never heard the word 'malnutrition'.

Giving colostrum to the newborn and exclusive breastfeeding for first 6 months of a child's life are not commonly practiced: 51 per cent of the mothers did not give colostrum to the newborn soon after birth and 58 per cent mothers fed water to their infants before 6 months.

Hand washing with soap is not a common practice: 11 per cent mothers said they used soap to wash hands before a meal and 19 per cent do so after a visit to the toilet.

Anganwadi Centres are widespread but not always efficient: There is an Anganwadi Centre in 96 per cent of the villages, 61 per cent of them in pucca buildings; the Anganwadi service accessed by the largest proportion of mothers (86 per cent) is immunization; 61 per cent of Anganwadi Centres had dried rations available and 50 per cent provided food on the day of survey; only 19 per cent of the mothers reported that the Anganwadi Centre provides nutrition counseling to parents.

The government has launched a large number of programmes and schemes to address major concerns and bridge the gaps in existing health infrastructure and provide accessible, affordable, equitable health care. These include the NRHM, National Programme for Health Care of the Elderly (NPHCE), National Mental Health Programme, NPCDCS, Pradhan